

Adultery, Gender Roles and Divergent Chronology: a Comparative Analysis between Anton Chekhov's "The Lady with the Dog" and Joyce Carol Oates' "The Lady with the Pet Dog"

Anton Chekhov's "The Lady with the Dog" presents a timeless short story about an act of infidelity and ethereal love. It focuses on the adulterous relationship between Gurov and Sergeyevna, through the lens of societal expectations in a volatile Russia. Published in 1899, it stood as one of Chekhov's most celebrated literary works, so well-received that a thematic response to this short story came in the form of Joyce Carol Oates' "The Lady with the Pet Dog" in 1972. Her short story similarly describes the adultery of Anna and an unnamed man, and the moral dilemmas she faces juggling her two lifestyles as a woman. While both short stories are nearly identical in terms of basic story, characters, and ideas, they differ greatly on the deeper messages and literary mechanics presented, creating a duality in which the stories both mirror yet contrast each other in many ways. Both Chekhov's "The Lady with the Dog" and Oates' "The Lady with the Pet Dog" focus on the idea of conforming to and breaking gender roles and how they interact with morals in adultery, using differing time-based writing mechanics.

Supporting this is David Carey Jr.'s "Lost Labor and Love: Adultery in Early Twentieth-Century Guatemala." A historical, peer-reviewed study of the ethics and context of marriage, adultery, and how they interacted with society as a whole in twentieth century Guatemala, this article explains the reasoning people use for cheating as well as the results of it, from the sides of both genders, helping to show the differing views that the narrators in the two short stories experience. Carey focuses on both sides of the relationships and how cheating was both justified and not, for both genders in the historical context of a patriarchal Guatemala, presenting a unique perspective that both conforms to and breaks traditional gender roles in

terms of relationship dynamics, transcending just Guatemalan society and showing how gender roles as a whole control societal interactions such as adultery.

In Chekhov's "The Lady with the Dog", Gurov's view on women and life itself changes through the catalyst of adultery, making him a more empathetic, emotional person. Initially, Gurov treats women with disdain, stating that they are a "lesser race" (Chekhov 72). Through this statement, Gurov is revealed to be a man who views women as mere playthings for pleasure, going from one adulterous relationship to the next without considering the feelings of the women or his wife, the transgression of infidelity not a major breach to him. However, as Gurov cheats with his newest woman, Sergeryevna, he begins to feel actual feelings of love, empathy, and becomes a more respectful man, stating "everything that was important, interesting, essential, everything about which he was sincere and never deceived himself, everything that composed the kernel of his life, went on in secret" (Chekhov 83). This creates an interesting moral dilemma in which it is obvious Gurov is a much better and happier person overall, but the object of this elation is a result of infidelity. Yet, Gurov decides to enjoy himself in this new lifestyle rather than making the morally correct decision to end it, having little worry about the morals or repercussions of his choice. Carey writes that "gender relations became a relationship of power intrinsically related to the power and organization of the patriarchal state", showing how traditional gender roles supported Gurov to make the decision to not end the relationship (Carey 232). Due to historical gender roles significantly empowering men, Gurov had the liberty to make this choice with much less worry about the repercussions due to the historical context, in which many societies before the 21st century were entirely male dominated. While women were severely punished and ostracized for adultery, most men were let off with punishments ranging from a wrist slap to nothing at all. In contrast, Oates' short story focuses much more on the moral

dilemma presented with cheating, with many paragraphs spent on Anna's frantic thoughts about the betrayal to her husband versus the absolute love she feels for her new partner, entirely due to the patriarchy ensuring that Gurov's cheating would not be a big deal but Anna's cheating would be a major scandal. This further highlights the importance of gender roles in adultery, as Anna's position in society as a high-class woman is fully dependent on her bond with her husband, and severing it would forsake her status in society permanently. The physical settings of the two short stories and their context also highlight this contrast in gender roles, with Gurov noticing "The water was a warm, tender purple, the moonlight lay on its surface in a golden strip", constantly noting the splendor of Yalta, where all of the cheating began (Chekhov 73). In contrast, he constantly describes his home with his wife and children, Moscow, as a cold and barren land with no descriptions of color. While the land in which Gurov experiences true love is a paradise of color and vibrancy, his home is a land which he grows to despise and feel imprisoned in. Oates' Anna has the same thought process, with her fondly recalling the picturesque beach in which she met her lover, yet simply calls any other place by its given name, such as Albany, giving it no grandiose description. The settings act as a way to further depict the difference in gender roles, as Gurov notices the stark contrast between the place where he experiences color, joy, and adultery, in Yalta, and the cold, barren land of Moscow in which he is restrained from that happiness. Anna mirrors this, only giving a positive description to the place where the infidelity began, yet she also views that joy as a negative due to the fact that she was committing such a sin, showing how all of her mental struggles focused on the physical setting in which she began cheating, which may destroy her social life entirely if revealed. In contrast, Gurov is free to make both physical and mental distinctions between these two settings, as he literally leaves Moscow multiple times to go to places that make him happier with Sergeyevna due to his status

in the patriarchy, unlike Anna who is mentally stuck between those two physical places due to her fear of becoming a pariah due to her oppressed gender role.

Further exploring the dynamics of gender roles is Oates' "The Lady with the Pet Dog", in which Anna begins an adulterous connection with an unnamed man. Unlike Gurov, Anna has a significant mental struggle due to the cheating, constantly debating whether accepting true love yet also destroying her sacred marriage vows is the right decision. This is due to her gender role as a woman, completely dependent on the man in the relationship to elevate her financial and societal status. However, she begins to transcend her gender role by taking a dominant position in the relationship, constantly seeing her husband as someone getting "softer, heavier", while he takes a more emotional, feminine role in the dynamic, asking her "Did I hurt you?", showing uncharacteristic emotion and femininity for the time period (Oates 2, 6). Sergeyevna reflects the same power shift, telling Gurov her husband is a flunkey (a submissive servant), Gurov immediately noticing "there really was something of the lackey's servility in his lanky figure, his side-whiskers, and the little bald spot on the top of his head" when seeing the husband for the first time (Chekhov 81). These transgressions of gender roles allow the women to assume a male role in the relationship with their spouses, justifying their adultery to themselves and satisfying the moral dilemma of cheating that affects both Anna and Sergeyevna by assuming the male gender role that does not have to worry about severe punishment for adultery. Carey writes on this as well, noting "This ability to bend their gender roles afforded some women greater mobility and flexibility than men" to show how even in real historical context women were able to manipulate relations by morphing their gender roles (231). Both short stories are similar in this transcension beyond gender roles in terms of the women, as they both include the women expressing extreme grief and worry about the morals of what they are committing in terms of

infidelity. However, they differ in the fact that Sergeyevna only expresses this in her dialogue, as Gurov is the third-person narrator of the short story. In contrast, Anna's panicked mental debate is on full display in her short story, as she is the third-person narrator and her inner thoughts are constantly shown, her incessantly going back and forth between an acceptance of true love and self-loathing over the sin she has committed. Despite this, it is clear through both perspectives that, as Carey noted, women are actually given the unique ability to "bend their gender roles" which allowed unprecedented adaptability in terms of their social situations, empowering them to overcome their worries about punishment for adultery and fully enjoy the true love they felt outside the bounds of their imprisoning marriages (231). Furthermore, this ability also shows a disadvantage of the male gender role, as Carey specifically notes this ability only applies to women. If men were to "bend their gender roles", they would simply be lowering their status to that of a woman, becoming much less valued to society in patriarchal times, which is exactly what happens due to the lack of strength shown off by both Anna's and Sergeyevna's husbands being "soft" and a "lackey", which does morph the gender roles of their marriages entirely, the husbands taking a more submissive feminine role while the women become empowered, taking the masculine role in the relationship which allows them to justify and indulge in their adultery (Carey 231, Oates 2, Chekhov 81).

The two short stories also use the writing mechanics of chronology and time as an aspect of structure to demonstrate their differing gender roles and emotions. Chekhov uses a chronological order in his writing, depicting Gurov's point of view in the order in which the events happen. Throughout the short story, Gurov's thoughts are often self-centered and focus on his primary issues, that being his love at hand. The chronological order used directly shows his streamlined evolution in terms of happiness, when he notices that he experiences true joy with

Sergeyevna. The ethereal scene in which Chekhov writes “And it may be that in this continuity [of the ocean], this utter indifference to life and death, lies the secret of our ultimate salvation, of the stream of life on our planet, and of its never-ceasing movement towards perfection. Side by side with a young woman, who looked so exquisite in the early light, soothed and enchanted by the sight of all this magical beauty — sea, mountains, clouds and the vast expanse of the sky — Gurov told himself that, when you came to think of it, everything in the world is beautiful really” demonstrates somewhat of a transgression of chronological order, as if the love shared between Gurov and Sergeyevna transcends time itself and the infinite cycle of life and death on the universal scale (76). This scene stands out due to it being the most philosophical, spirited moment in Chekhov’s writing, somewhat breaking the chronological order established and highlighting how important their love is. In contrast, Oates utilizes a cyclical structure, having the story jump through time and continuously ending at the same point at which it started. This is used to emphasize the searing duality present in Anna’s mind, as she constantly replays the events which led to her reuniting with her lover at the concert, splitting her between accepting true love and punishing herself for betraying her husband. These mechanics of time in writing actually help to further nuance the impetus of gender roles, using them to emphasize aspects of their genders. Carey’s writing further supports this, as his study of 18th century Latin American marriage dynamics shows “As was true elsewhere in colonial and national Latin America, working class men and women in highland Guatemala generally approached marriage as a contract based upon mutual (albeit unequal) obligations; with few exceptions, the partnership perpetuated patriarchy”, depicting the idea that even across different countries, cultures, and time periods, unequal, patriarchal gender roles were steadfast in society (231). These ideas unify to show that in Gurov’s case, his gender role empowered him to further pursue true love through

adultery, which, chronologically, directly led him to experience that almost illusory scene at the sea in which he connects his love to something that goes beyond the infinities of time and the universe, which thematically breaks the chronological writing structure used. This ideal of a traditional gender role as a man, in which Gurov has much more liberty to cheat, aligns with Carey's focus on the traditional role of a man doing the intensive money making and social climbing in a relationship, the basis upon which patriarchy runs. In contrast, the gender role of a woman in Anna's case is emphasized by the cyclical writing nature, which doubles down on her worry by constantly leading back to the moment in which she suddenly found her lover at a concert, bringing back a flood of the traumatic and loving memories she had with him. This further reflects the ideal of traditional gender roles in Carey's writing, as she experiences this worry due to her being on the much more dangerous end of an adulterous relationship as a woman.

Anton Chekhov's "The Lady with the Dog" and Joyce Carol Oates' "The Lady with the Pet Dog" share very similar plot structures and characters, but the inherent gender roles and mechanics of time differentiate the stories greatly in terms of the deeper messages. Supported by David Carey Jr.'s "Lost Labor and Love: Adultery in Early Twentieth-Century Guatemala", which studies power dynamics and infidelity in Guatemalan society in a far-reaching historical context, it can be found that both short stories contain examples of traditional gender roles in patriarchal societies where men hold a majority of the power, and a transgression of gender roles in which women become empowered and men are submissive, to depict gender roles as a moral barrier to experiencing true love in an adulterous relationship.

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